by 35 runs, Aaqib Javed being the pick of our bowlers, claiming five wickets. And for the first time in the history of the India–Pakistan rivalry – or so I was told by my seniors – about 50,000-odd Indian spectators gave the visiting Pakistan team a standing ovation. Truly, it was great cricket all around.

As a rival, as a team to visit on tour and as a country, India is unequalled when it comes to love and respect for cricketers. India's fandom is unique and different from that of the rest of the cricketing world. The country's affection for the game is unparalleled. Yes, their politics is dirty – remember how the pitches in Mumbai were dug up by the Shiv Sena? Their media plays dirty too, when they build hype by quoting things out of context. I think India's media has played a terrible role in distancing the two countries – strange, when people of both countries want peace. And more cricket.

After that first match in Chennai, I would go on to play four or five more games against India. There was one in 1998 – the Independence Cup final in Dhaka. Then in 2004, when I captained Pakistan 'A'. Then in 2005, when we drew the Bangalore Test, under Inzi's leadership, and my famous Kanpur century (102 off 46, 10x4, 9x6). Then in 2007–8, under Shoaib Malik's captaincy, followed by the 2011 ICC World Cup and the T20s in 2012. What a journey it has been – to India and with India!

Over the years, Pakistan's tours to India got more complicated due to a host of issues, not all of them cricket-related. I've always believed, and I still do, that cricket is a great compromise between India and Pakistan. The game is a great stabilizer. It is the best way forward for normalization of relations between two estranged countries. Cricketers are the ambassadors, not just of the game, but of millions of people they represent and inspire.

With India, although our rivalry is the fiercest in the world, I believe that cricket is the best solution for peace. That's my single-line approach for normalizing Pakistan's relations with India: more cricket. Unfortunately, neither the Indian media nor the Indian government seem to agree. More on that later.

For now, I must admit something, even if it pains me to say this as a Pakistani. That initial psychological superiority we had established for years over the Indian team through the 1980s and maybe even the '90s has fizzled out. The magic of the famous Miandad six at Sharjah has worn off. For me, during the two decades that I played at the highest level, there's never been a better batting line-up in the modern game than the one India had during my time: Sachin, Dravid, Ganguly, Virender Sehwag, Yuvraj Singh. Now there's Virat Kohli.

For me, India was the most balanced, most dangerous side to bowl against. The rivalry is thus paramount. Period.